🌎 Imperialism: Reading

US History · Unit 6 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with Imperialism PQ, Should the US go to war with Spain?, Panama Canal reading, Cuba & Hawaii DBQ, cartoons

Name: _____

America Becomes a World Power

By the late 1800s American factories and farms produced more than Americans could buy. Business leaders wanted new markets and raw materials, the Navy wanted coaling stations for its ships, and many Americans believed the US should compete with European empires. Some used racist ideas, like Rudyard Kipling's “White Man's Burden,” to claim that other peoples needed to be ruled. This drive to control other lands is called imperialism.

The US bought Alaska from Russia in 1867 for $7.2 million; critics called it “Seward's Folly” until gold was discovered. In Hawaii, American sugar planters such as Sanford Dole controlled the economy. In 1893, backed by US Marines, they overthrew Queen Liliuokalani. Despite protests and petitions from Native Hawaiians, the US annexed Hawaii in 1898.

That same year Cubans were fighting for independence from Spain. Newspapers owned by William Randolph Hearst and Joseph Pulitzer printed exaggerated stories of Spanish cruelty, a style called yellow journalism. When the battleship USS Maine exploded in Havana harbor, killing 266 sailors, the papers blamed Spain with no proof. “Remember the Maine!” became a battle cry, and Congress declared war.

The Spanish-American War lasted about four months. Theodore Roosevelt's Rough Riders became famous for the charge up San Juan Hill, though Black “Buffalo Soldier” regiments fought beside them. Far more Americans died from yellow fever, typhoid and spoiled “embalmed beef” than from bullets. Spain gave up Puerto Rico and Guam and sold the Philippines for $20 million. Cuba became independent, but the Platt Amendment let the US intervene there. Filipinos who wanted independence fought a bloody war against US rule from 1899 to 1902.

As president, Roosevelt said the US should “speak softly and carry a big stick.” He sent the Great White Fleet around the world and helped Panama break away from Colombia so the US could build a canal. Workers battled malaria and yellow fever; most came from the Caribbean and were paid less than white Americans. The Panama Canal opened in 1914, linking the Atlantic and Pacific Oceans.

Check your reading

1. Give three reasons the US pursued imperialism.

2. How did yellow journalism contribute to the Spanish-American War?

3. What territories did the US gain in 1898?